

TTRPG Homebrewing

Day of Dungeons 2026



Nicholas Cornia, Orpheus Instituut



Powered by KoLC



Table of Content

Table of Content.....	2
What is this essay about?.....	4
Why homebrewing?.....	4
Aspects of Play.....	5
player characters.....	6
Character Creation.....	6
Lifepath.....	6
Game of 20 questions.....	6
Random Tables.....	6
Attributes and Talents.....	7
Descriptive Aspects.....	7
Approach-based Attributes.....	7
Attributes as Resources.....	7
Non-prescriptive Skill System.....	7
Special Abilities and Gear.....	7
Free-form Magic System.....	7
Crew Mechanics.....	7
Relations and Drives.....	8
Bonds.....	8
Beliefs, Goals, Instincts.....	8
Personality Traits.....	8
Strings.....	8
Helping and Teamwork.....	8
Help, or Interfere!.....	8
Assist.....	9
Progression and Rewards.....	9
Failure-based and Diegetic Progression.....	9
End-of-game Questions.....	9
Progress Track.....	9
Keys.....	9
Dealing with Death.....	10
Surrender and Blaze of Glory.....	10
Death Roulette.....	10
Death Tower.....	10
Players.....	11
Conflict Resolution.....	11
Betting and Pushing your Luck.....	12
Action Points during Conflicts.....	12
Codified Actions and Abstract Conflicts.....	12
Resource Management.....	12
Aleatoric Resources.....	12
Conditions.....	12

Resource Ecosystem.....	12
Shared Metacurrency.....	13
GM's Metacurrency.....	13
Narrative Agency and Worldbuilding.....	13
Dramatic Wounds.....	13
Worldbuilding Agency.....	13
Game Masters.....	14
Degrees of Success.....	14
Tripartite Degrees of Success.....	14
Fictional Positioning.....	15
Fronts and Oppositions.....	15
Fronts.....	15
Oracles and Tables.....	15
Oracles.....	15
Tarot Cards.....	15
Encounter Design.....	15
Monster Roles.....	16
Initiative System.....	16
Escalation Mechanic.....	16
Time Management and Procedural Play.....	16
The Grind.....	16
Journeys and Travel.....	16
Resources.....	18
Selected Bibliography.....	18
Tabletop Games.....	19
Web Resources.....	20
Knights of Last Calls.....	21

What is this essay about?

This short essay is the result of a workshop given by the author during the tabletop role-playing games' festival *Day of Dungeon*¹, organized in the beautiful Saint Peter's abbey in the heart of Ghent, Belgium. The workshop's aim was to encourage game masters to improve their group's experience by introducing homebrew rules inspired by a variety of tabletop role-playing games.

Disclaimer

The games that are cited in the following essay are part of the personal repertoire of the author, built from reading, studying, playing and homebrewing. You, dear reader, might have included some of your favorite games to illustrate some of the several aspects of play and game-mechanics this workshop addressed. Contrary to board games, to the best of my knowledge, there have not been any comprehensive books about tabletop role-playing games². The TTRPG hobby is always evolving, driven by an active community of GMs, game designers and players. The act of homebrewing is a peculiar characteristic of this unique artform, with the resulting consequences. Let's try to make some sense out of all of it, shall we?

Why homebrewing?

Since the beginning of modern tabletop role-playing games, homebrewing has been an integral part of this peculiar hobby. Contrary to its close relative the board game, TTRPGs have a more interactive and creative approach towards rules and game-mechanics.

In the introduction of his book *The Stuff Games are Made Of*, game designer Pippin Barr states that "the rules, which often seem set in stone, suddenly become material for playful exploration through design" (Barr 2023). Thus, playing *with* the rules could be a game on its own. Through this brief essay we are going to acquire awareness and critical understanding of an activity we have been doing since our childhood: step into a magic circle with our fellow players and shape its boundaries in order to provide a satisfactory and compelling experience of our emergent shared fantasy.

A huge part of what makes childhood play so wholehearted is playing with the rules, not just by them.

Pippin Barr

¹<https://dayofdungeons.be/>

² An example of a comprehensive book about board games is Arnaudo, Marco. 2024. *The Tabletop Revolution: Gaming Reimagined in the 21st Century*. Studies in Gaming. Jefferson: McFarland & Company, Inc., Publishers. The tabletop role-playing games community lacks an equivalent study. An interesting catalogue of TTRPGs is Horvath, Stu. 2023. *Monsters, Aliens, and Holes in the Ground: A Guide to Tabletop Roleplaying Games from D&D to Mothership*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: MIT Press.

For a game master homebrewing can be exciting, bringing an additional tool to their already broad arsenal. Driven by the best intentions, game masters will start looking at every rule from their book in order to tweak them, bringing confusion and even malcontent at the table. In order to prevent unpleasant situations, the best advice is to:

- **Introduce rules progressively:** Rome has not been built in a day. The same holds for a homebrewed TTRPG.
- **Be transparent to fellow players:** Ask for players' feedback at the end of each session, taking into account their comments in order to improve the experience at the table for the next session. Furthermore, it is crucial to discuss with the players custom rules during Session 0.
- **Motivate your choices:** An homebrew rule should address a specific aspect of play in order to improve the communal experience at the table. Avoid arbitrary choices, and be careful while tweaking core-mechanics.
- **Don't forget that your TTRP has been extensively playtested:** Even though a rule might not sound interesting for your table, it is part of an ecosystem of other game-mechanics that have been playtested by thousands of skilled players before reaching the printing press. Think about the overall impact of a rule change with respect to the game system as a whole.

Aspects of Play

Engaging in a tabletop role-playing game is a complex experience, aiming to immerse the players in a coherent imaginary world where a compelling narrative arises driven by the communal contribution of everybody at the table. The back-and-forward interaction between the game-mechanics and the shared fantasy – or the *fiction* – is responsible for the emergence of a rich playing space, with seemingly endless possibilities. According to game designer Joris Dormans, emergence – i.e. complex structures arising from a relatively simple rule-set – is linked to feedback loops. It is through nonhierarchical and non-linear interaction between rules and players that a compelling, emergent gameplay arises (Dormans 2012).

A series of fundamental aspects of play have emerged from the critical study of a corpus of tabletop role-playing games and the inspiring conversations from the community of *Knights of Last Call*, led by Derik Melenda.³

The following classification of aspects is based on three major agents of a tabletop role-playing game: players, game masters and player characters.

³Official YouTube channel: <https://www.youtube.com/@KnightsOfLastCall>, Patreon page: <https://www.patreon.com/knightsoflastcall>.

Player Characters



We would be tempted to assume that player characters, or PCs, and their actual players should share the same drives and motivations: this attitude – usually driven by an overemphasized immersion – is a reductive one and cuts off a whole set of compelling playing trajectories. Based on this assumption, we are going to explore how different games handle player characters' agency.

Character Creation

The generation of a fictional persona, inhabiting a shared imaginary world, could be considered – using Tolkien's terminology – an act of *subcreation* (Wolf 2014). The process of creating a character is unfortunately one of the few moments of real agency of the player in the imaginary world during a campaign. The character is sacred to the player, and their past is avidly kept with the ownership of its creator. Some of the games presented here, deals with some issues related to the creation of a character, opening up possibilities for co-creation, some randomness and flexible design.

Lifepath

Example of *lifepath character creation* in *Traveller* (Matthew Sprange and Marc Miller 2022).

Game of 20 questions

Example of *question-based character creation*, using the game of 20 questions in *Legend of the Five Rings 5th Edition* (Brooke and Ostrander 2021).

Random Tables

Examples of *random tables* applied in order to build a random character in *Forbidden Lands* (Christian Granath et al. 2018) and *Dragonbane* (Härenstam 2023).

Attributes and Talents

One of the distinctive features of TTRPs, with respect to simpler games of make-believe, is the quantization of player character's skills and attributes. Some games attempt to systematize every aspect of a PC into a clear set of prescriptive skills and attributes, while other TTRPGs model characters based on abstract motivations or approaches, or even descriptive aspects.

Descriptive Aspects

Example of *aspect mechanics* in *FATE* (Komoda 2013) with descriptive facets that players, and the GM, can invoke in order to get advantages or twists.

Approach-based Attributes

Example of *approach-based attribute*, using abstract elemental energies (Rings) to indicate a player character's approach towards a conflict or task in *Legend of the Five Rings 5th Edition*.

Attributes as Resources

Example of character attributes in *Forbidden Lands* that serve as *stress mechanic* and resource. Instead of hit points, characters lose temporary ranks in their attributes.

Non-prescriptive Skill System

In *13th Age 1st Edition* (Heinsoo and Tweet 2013) there is no prescriptive list of skills, instead the player characters have descriptive aspects called Backgrounds which reflect the PC's training and former profession and experiences. If it makes sense in the fiction, the player receives the background bonus ratings in order to succeed in the conflict.

Special Abilities and Gear

From fantasy to science fiction RPG genres, player characters stand out from the crowd by using magic, unique items, state-of-the-art equipment, vehicles and animal companions.

Free-form Magic System

Example of hybrid *free-form magic system* in *Fabula Ultima* (Galletto 2022) with Rituals and codified spells, very similar to *13th Age 1st Edition*.

Dungeonworld (LaTorra et al. 2014) also uses a *free-form magic system* for out-of-combat spells, codified within a specific *move mechanic*.

Crew Mechanics

Example of *crew mechanic* in the form of a shared spaceship in *Scum and Villainy* (Acimovic and Leboeuf-Little 2018) and stronghold in *Forbidden Lands*.

Relations and Drives

Bonds, goals and motivations are the driving force behind player characters' agency. As stated by the Mouse Guard's motto:

It matters not what you fight, but what you fight for.

Mouseguard 2nd Edition(Crane 2016)

Because TTRPGs have an intrinsic game component alongside its storytelling features, many game designers have structured how player characters relate to their imaginary world, creating a series of mechanics that foster the fruitful feedback loop between rules and fiction. Players are rewarded by the game system if they align their character's action according to their drives, beliefs and relations.

Bonds

Example of *bond mechanic* in *Fabula Ultima*, where the player character is tied to another person, a place, an organization or a culture in the game world.

Beliefs, Goals, Instincts

Example of *aspect mechanic* and *personality mechanic* in the form of Beliefs, Goals, and Instincts in *Mouse Guard*. These descriptive statements encourage the players to take actions for their characters accordingly.

Personality Traits

Games like *Pendragon 6th Edition* (Stafford 2024) represent the player character's personality into codified mechanics. Our knight has a series of values tied to Traits and Passions that will evolve according to the deeds taken during gameplay.

Strings

In games such as *Monsterhearts* (Avery Alder, n.d.) and *Thirsty Sword Lesbians* (Walsh 2021), players accumulate a special type of metacurrency called *strings*. They can use these points in order to have narrative control on another player.

Helping and Teamwork

Interaction between players is what makes tabletop role-playing games so compelling. A group of player characters, often called a *party*, combines their skills and talents in order to achieve heroic deeds of eternal glory.

Some games provide specific rules for collective conflicts, where multiple players roll dice together. Also helping is codified and often requires players to spend valuable resources in order to assist their companions.

Help, or Interfere!

Example of *helping mechanic* in *Root RPG* (Conway and Diaz Truman 2021), involving spending a resource called Exhaustion in order to be performed. Note that in *Root* players can either Help or Interfere with a fellow PC.

Assist

In *Outgunned Adventure RPG* (Formicola and Sirignano 2025), players can store dice after a roll into a shared collection in order to represent support for future players' actions. In this fashion, even a failed check has a potential positive impact for the party in order to overcome an obstacle.

Progression and Rewards

Role-playing games have always taken a dangerous position within the game studies' milieu. Because of their lack of clear and pre-defined goals, some scholars have even excluded them from the status of game, based on a definition of game and play that include some sort of goal-oriented experience (Salen and Zimmerman 2004; Upton 2015). In order to reward players, if they align their player character's actions with their personal or game master's agendas, the game system provides a series of progression mechanics that deals with advancement – usually in the form of new powers and features.

As Derik Melenda always says during his livestreams:

What gets rewarded gets repeated, what gets measured gets managed.

If a game rewards a certain behavior, players will be inclined to repeat that set of actions in order to progress their characters. Clear and codified rewards can feed virtuous players' behavior through incentives (carrots) rather than penalties (sticks).

Failure-based and Diegetic Progression.

Example of *failure-based progression* for skill advancement in *Torchbearer 2nd Edition* (Olavsrud and Crane 2021). In order to gain ranks in a given skill, player characters have to collect a number of successes and failures during adventuring. This progression mechanic is called *diegetic progression*, meaning that the character is improving their talents by in-game experience and training.

End-of-game Questions

Example of *question-based progression* at the end of the session in order to buy progression checks in *Dragonbane* and *Forbidden Lands*.

Progress Track

In *Ironsworn* (Tomkin 2018), a set of specific codified actions – through a *move mechanic* – are responsible for the progress of a player character.

Keys

In *Lady Blackbird* (Harper 2016) each character has a list of Keys, descriptive aspects that provide experience points every time they are triggered. A Key can be exhausted in exchange for extra XPs, leading to a fundamental change in the character's motivations.

Dealing with Death

Heroes are not immortal, and often their quest requires them to pay the highest price in order to fulfil their mission: their own lives. Dealing with character's death has been a very controversial topic in TTRPG design: while the more Old School Renaissance and simulationist approach denies any form of plot armour, more narrative-oriented games have given more decision power to players for their PCs' last breath. On the other hand, more gamist-oriented games – such as *Pathfinder 2nd Edition* – have made death nearly impossible by turning the game's statistics and balance openly in favour of the players, providing the illusion of danger.

Surrender and Blaze of Glory

Example of player agency regarding death of their PC in *Daggerheart* (Spenser Starke et al. 2025), very similar to *Fabula Ultima*. In both games, when a character runs out of life points, the player might choose to surrender, sacrifice themselves or risk it all while trying to stand up and fight back.

Death Roulette

In *Outgunned Adventure*, when a player character runs out of stress boxes, they are going to roll on a Death Roulette to see if they face death. Other players can intervene in order to save them by using a *narrative mechanic* called Spotlight.

Death Tower

In more narrative and *low-prep tabletop roleplaying-games*, players share a physical pool of objects, like dice or Jenga blocks, representing their life. In *Dread* (Ravachol and Barmore 2006), the fall of the Jenga tower signifies the death of a player, while in *The Job* (Novoa 2024) the fall of a pile of dice escalates the heist, eventually leading to the party's arrestation, or worst.

Players



In his *Manifesto for a Ludic Century*, game scholar Eric Zimmerman states that "playing games is part of what it means to be human" (Zimmerman 2015). We play because we wish to experience situations otherwise impossible – or extremely inconvenient or even dangerous (Bowman 2010). By stepping into a shared, imaginary *magic circle*, we commit to the unique experience of play. As declared by Frank Lantz in his *The Beauty of Games*, "games are the art form about choices and consequences" (Lantz 2023). Several games provide a variety of mechanics in order to allow players' agency in the form of resources, metacurrency and narrative potential.

Conflict Resolution

Many *Powered by the Apocalypse* games describe a tabletop role-playing session as the *conversation* – a dialectic exchange of narrative between game master and players. But contrary to collective storytelling, moments of uncertainty are usually resolved through game-mechanics. When the unfolding of the shared story is unclear, TTRPGs provide the players with procedures in order to determine the outcome of a conflict, or a tense situation. Some games use randomized tools in order to achieve interesting outcomes, while others rely on deterministic tools usually in the form of players' resource management. In most of the cases, a balance between predictable outcomes and uncertain ones is employed. By setting up their fictional positioning, or exploiting their character's attributes and talents, players can increase their odds of success for a given conflict.

Crucial for our discussion are the concepts of *input randomness* and *output randomness*, the first places the player's decision after a random event, such as rolling a dice pool, while the latter lets first state the player's intention before the randomizing tool is acting.⁴

⁴For a brief overview on the concepts of input and output randomness, have a look at this video by Keith Burgun: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2qfFEP-LkI>.

Betting and Pushing your Luck

Example of *dice pool mechanic*/*dice pool* and *pushing mechanic* in *Outgunned Adventure*.

Action Points during Conflicts

System of Raises in *7th Sea 2nd Edition* (Wick 2016), allowing players to take actions during a turn in order to overcome a conflict.

Codified Actions and Abstract Conflicts

Example of *codified actions* in *Torchbearer 2nd Edition*, performed in a rock-paper-scissors fashion, where players secretly decide three actions per turn against the game master's opposition. Conflicts are resolved using skill rolls based on the selected action, increasing or reducing an abstract resource called Disposition.

Resource Management

Modern tabletop role-playing games borrow a lot from board game design, especially regarding the managing of the internal game economy of players' resources. Those resources can be either abstract, usually called *metacurrencies*, or more or less concrete, such as inventory objects, or physical features of characters.

For both players and game masters, resources are crucial in order for them to leverage the otherwise unpredictable and aleatoric playing space. Both can decide to spend resources in order to push the collective narrative according to their personal agenda and motivations.

Aleatoric Resources

Example of *aleatoric resources* for survival in *Forbidden Lands*. Instead of many games, tracking characters' resources in weight and bulk, resources such as water, food and ammunition are tied to a polyhedral die ranging from d4 to d12.

Conditions

Example of marking *conditions* in order to re-roll a failed check in *Dragonbane*. Once the condition is marked, the player character receives a Bane (disadvantage) for all skill checks related to that given attribute.

Resource Ecosystem

Avatar Legends (Conway and Diaz Truman 2022) uses a complex ecosystem of resources from Conditions, Stress boxes, and Balance track as *personality mechanic* in order to provide both players and GM with a systematic way to translate fictional consequences into resource tracking.

Shared Metacurrency

In *Genesys RPG* (Stewart and Little 2021), players share a common pool of Story Points in order to control the narrative of the game. Every time a player uses a die, it goes into the GM's pool and can be used later to make the party's life more challenging, returning back to the players.

Similarly, games such as *Scum and Villainy* (Gambit) and *The One Ring 2nd Edition* (Fellowship Points), use *shared metacurrency* among the players.

GM's Metacurrency

The One Ring 2nd Edition (Nepitello 2022) uses a players' metacurrency called Hope and a GM one called Shadow Points, reflecting the struggle of Middle Earth's character to resist the darkness provided by Sauron's grip. Similarly, in *7th Sea 2nd Edition* both players and GM have metacurrency resources, respectively called Hero and Danger Points.

Narrative Agency and Worldbuilding

In many TTRPGs, the ability to decide events and entities in the shared imaginary world is almost an exclusive prerogative of the game master. Indie role-playing games, arising from the fruitful discussions of Ron Edwards' *The Forge* online community in the early 2000s, have introduced specific game-mechanics and metacurrencies in order to allow players to take a more directorial stance at the table.⁵ Some role-playing games even take a step forward, democratizing the narrative leverage to all players equally by removing the game master role.

Dramatic Wounds

Dramatic Wounds system for tracking player characters' health that emulates the swashbuckling genre of *7th Sea 2nd Edition*. The closer to death a hero is, the greater their deeds will be before taking the last breath.

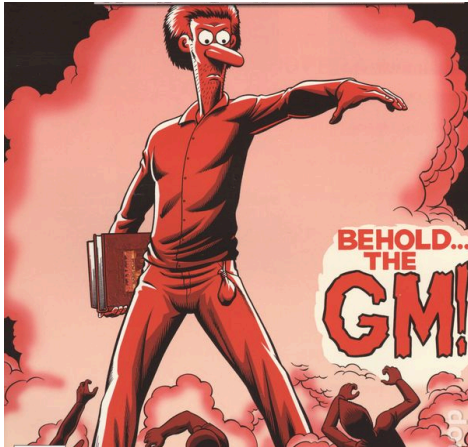
Worldbuilding Agency

In *Fabula Ultima* and *FATE*, players can spend their metacurrency in order to create elements in the shared imaginary world of the game.

In Ben Robbins' games, such as *Microscope* (Robbins 2011), worldbuilding becomes a game in itself, allowing players to actively participate in the creation of the shared imaginary world of the campaign.

⁵Original articles derived from the forum can be retrieved at <http://www.indie-rpgs.com/articles/>.

Game Masters



Another distinctive feature of tabletop role-playing games is the figure of the game master. Many leisure activities and parlor games – from Italian literary circles to Victorian salons – have always included a moderator, or facilitator figure whose role is to coordinate and make judgments on the spot.

As stated in *Dungeon World* first edition (LaTorra et al. 2014), the game master role is summarized by the following agenda:

- **Portray a fantastic world:** GM are the vehicle through which players experience their character's surroundings. Keeping consistency and verisimilitude in the shared imaginary world is the recipe for a successful immersive experience.
- **Fill the characters' lives with adventure:** The game master should both "be a fan of the PCs" and fill their characters' lives with dangers and thrilling quests.
- **Play to find out what happens:** The unfolding story at the table should not be determined beforehand, but rather be the emergent result of the collective decisions made during play. The GM should be equally surprised about the outcomes of the story as anybody else at the table.

Degrees of Success

Mainstream TTRPGs such as *Dungeons & Dragon* use a core mechanic for conflict resolution that provides a binary outcome: either the player character succeeds at their task, or they miserably fail. A legacy of games, since the early 1980s, have introduced a richer spectrum of *degrees of success*, providing the game master more flexibility in determining outcomes of conflicts.

Tripartite Degrees of Success

Powered by the *Apocalypse* games, such as *Thirsty Sword Lesbians*, share a tripartite system of

- **Downbeat/Miss:** where the GM takes narrative power, usually causing troubles to the PCs.
- **Mixed Beat/Success at a cost:** The player succeeds, but the GM introduces a complication.
- **Upbeat/Success:** where the player owns narrative agency for the action.

Fictional Positioning

Concept of Position and Effect in *Blades in the Dark* (Harper 2017). The impact and consequences of an action are stated after the player description by the GM, according to the *fictional positioning* of the player character.

Fronts and Oppositions

It is the GM's responsibility to let the players feel that their imaginary world is a dynamic, ever-evolving entity adapting according to the PCs' actions. In order to codify abstract concepts – like reputation with respect to a given organization, the dooming unfolding of a villainous plan or the countdown of an alarm – games have introduced rules in order to tangibly measure the evolution of the fictional world.

Fronts

Dungeonworld is one of the first Indie games mechanizing factions and events in a shared fantasy world by introducing the concept of Fronts. Thanks to this descriptive mechanic, players are aware of the consequences and time pressure related to a villainous plan, or an impending doom.

Oracles and Tables

Since the time humans have looked at the stars and imagined all sorts of tales, shapes and beings, we have been desperately creating procedures and devices in order to predict the future. Fortune-telling books of the Middle Ages and Early Modernity are an interesting example of how randomized procedures were applied in order to fulfil people's inherent curiosity about the unknown state of the universe we call future. In tabletop role-playing games, oracles take the form of – sometimes very esoteric – random tables in order to generate future outcomes, or even determine scenes.

Oracles

Example of complete set of oracle tables and rules for *solo RPG* playing in *Ironsworn RPG*. Instead of a game master, the game delegates decision-making to a series of random tables that regulate almost any aspect of the narrative.

Tarot Cards

The archetypal figures of the tarot deck are powerful emblems that can create tales and interpret the past, future and present. In tabletop role-playing games, variations on tarots have been used as resolution mechanic – in *Everway* (Tweet 1995) – or as powerful random tables – as in the Indie game *Fortunes Wheel* (Peter Hollinghurst 2015).

Encounter Design

In order to challenge the gamist soul of players, game masters are asked to design interesting encounters. An interesting and meaningful gameplay usually provides challenges for both the player and their character. Several games provide useful advice for game masters in order to create varied and interesting encounters for the players to solve. Monsters, hazards and puzzles become an opportunity for problem-solving.

Monster Roles

Monster roles have been extensively and consistently applied in *Dungeons & Dragons 4th Edition* (James Wyatt 2008), providing GMs with a flexible toolbox for encounters, instead of a long list of pre-made monsters.

Initiative System

Peculiar initiative system in *Hackmaster* (Kenzer and Company 2012), trying to simulate the passage of time during a combat exchange, poorly represented with classical turn-based initiative of most games.

Escalation Mechanic

In *13th Age 1st Edition*, on every round of combat an Escalation Die increases, making the PCs more powerful and more inclined to use their greatest abilities. This restriction encourages players to spare their best abilities for later turns, creating a non-trivial and complex decision-making process for the party.

Time Management and Procedural Play

According to Gary Gygax, one of the founding fathers of the hobby, one of the crucial abilities of a game master was the tracking of in-game time. This advice was given in a time and place where multiple players were engaging with a shared imaginary world run by a single GM asynchronously, but nevertheless the structuring of time phases in modern games remains crucial.

Players wasting time might have serious consequences, like random encounters on the route, or let the advancement of clocks and fronts. Some games, most remarkably *Forged in the Dark* and *Burning Wheel* derivatives, have divided play in distinctive phases influencing time pacing, player agency and rules.

Several levels of abstraction and granularity are employed in travel, journey and exploration in different tabletop role-playing games, ranging from high simulationist survival hex-crawling to point-crawl travel. Derik Melenda's definition of three distinct types of travel forms in TTRPG are:

- **Travel:** destination and route are known to the players.
- **Journey:** destination is known, but no clear route.
- **Exploration:** both destination and route are unknown.

The Grind

Example of playing phases and time mechanic in the form of the Grind in *Torchbearer 2nd Edition*. Every four skill checks during adventuring, player characters gain a condition that can only be restored during Camping or Town phases. This mechanic emulates the dangers linked to exploration of Old School D&D.

Journeys and Travel

Procedural Journey rules can be found in *The One Ring 2nd Edition*, while a more gamist and streamlined ruleset for travel can be found in *Fabula Ultima RPG*.

Other relevant games that address travelling and journeys are *The Wild Sea RPG* (Isaacs 2022) and *Wanderhome* (Dragon and Bi 2022).

Resources

Selected Bibliography

- Alexander, Justin. 2023. *So You Want to Be a Game Master: Everything You Need to Start Your Tabletop Adventure - for Dungeons & Dragons, Pathfinder and Other Systems*. Salem: Page Street Publishing.
- Arnaudo, Marco. 2024. *The Tabletop Revolution: Gaming Reimagined in the 21st Century*. Studies in Gaming. Jefferson: McFarland & Company, Inc., Publishers.
- Barr, Pippin. 2023. *The Stuff Games Are Made Of*. MIT Press.
- Bowman, Sarah Lynne. 2010. *The Functions of Role-Playing Games: How Participants Create Community, Solve Problems and Explore Identity*. Jefferson North Carolina London: McFarland & Company.
- Cover, Jennifer Grouling. 2010. *The Creation of Narrative in Tabletop Role-Playing Games*. Jefferson, North Carolina London: McFarland & Company, Inc., Publishers.
- Dormans, Joris. 2012. 'Engineering Emergence: Applied Theory for Game Design'. Research HvA, graduation external, Amsterdam: Universiteit van Amsterdam.
- Horvath, Stu. 2023. *Monsters, Aliens, and Holes in the Ground: A Guide to Tabletop Roleplaying Games from D&D to Mothership*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: MIT Press.
- Lantz, Frank. 2023. *The Beauty of Games*. MIT Press.
- Salen, Katie, and Eric Zimmerman. 2004. *Rules of Play: Game Design Fundamentals*. Cambridge, Mass: MIT Press.
- Schrier, Karen, Evan Torner, and Jessica Hammer. 2018. 'Worldbuilding in Role-Playing Games'. In *Role-Playing Game Studies*, 349–63. Routledge.
- Silverstein, Jenna. 2019. *Complete Kobold Guide to Game Design*. Kobold Press.
- Upton, Brian. 2015. *The Aesthetic of Play*. The MIT Press Series. Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press.
- Wolf, Mark. 2014. *Building Imaginary Worlds: The Theory and History of Subcreation*. 1st edition. Routledge.
- Zimmerman, Eric. 2015. 'Manifesto for a Ludic Century'. In *The Gameful World: Approaches, Issues, Applications*, 19–22. MIT Press.

Tabletop Games

- Acimovic, Stras, and John Leboeuf-Little. 2018. *Scum and Villainy: A Forged in the Dark Roleplaying Game*. Silver Spring MD: Evil Hat Productions.
- Avery Alder. n.d. *Monsterhearts 2: A Game about the Messy Lives of Teenage Monsters*. 2nd ed. Buried Without Ceremony.
- Brooke, Max, and Katrina Ostrander. 2021. *Legend of the Five Rings: Roleplaying : Core Rulebook*. Roseville, MN: Fantasy Flight Games.
- Christian Granath, Christian Granath, Nils Karlén, and Tomas Harenstam. 2018. *Forbidden Lands: Core Boxed Set*. 1st ed. Free League Publishing.
- Conway, Brendan, and Mark Diaz Truman. 2021. *Root: The Roleplaying Game : Core Book*. Magpie Games.
- . 2022. *Avatar Legends: The Roleplaying Game*. 1st ed. [Albuquerque, New Mexico]: Magpie Games.
- Crane, Luke. 2016. *Mouse Guard Roleplaying Game Boxed Set*. Los Angeles, CA: Archaia.
- . 2021. *The Burning Wheel: Fantasy Roleplaying System*. Gold edition revised. The Burning Wheel.
- Dragon, Jay, and Sylvia Bi. 2022. *Wanderhome*. Second printing edition 2022. Saugerties, NY: Possum Creek Games.
- Fate: Accelerated*. 2013. Silver Spring, MD: Evil Hat Productions.
- Formicola, Simone, and Riccardo Sirignano. 2025. *Outgunned Adventure*. Two Little Mice. <https://twolittlemice.net/ogadventure/>.
- Galletto, Emanuele. 2022. *Fabula Ultima TTJRPG: Core Rulebook*. [Milan, Italy]: Need Games.
- Härenstam, Tomas. 2023. *Dragonbane. Rulebook*. Stockholm: Free League.
- Harper, John. 2016. “Lady Blackbird.” Itch.io. <https://johnharper.itch.io/lady-blackbird>.
- . 2017. *Blades in the Dark*. Silver Spring, MD: Evil Hat Productions.
- Heinsoo, Rob, and Jonathan Tweet. 2013. *13th Age: A Fantasy Roleplaying Game*. Pelgrane Press.
- Isaacs, Felix. 2022. *The Wildsea*. 1st ed. Arcadia, CA: Mythopoeia.
- James Wyatt. 2008. *Dungeons & Dragons: Dungeon Master’s Guide*. 4th ed. Wizards of the Coast.
- Kenzer and Company. 2012. *Hackmaster: Player’s Handbook*. Kenzer and Company.
- Komoda, Kurt. 2013. *Fate: Core System*. Silver Spring, MD: Evil Hat Productions.
- LaTorra, Sage, Adam Koebel, and RNDM Games, LLC. 2014. *Dungeon World*. First ed. [Kirkland, WA]: Sage Kobold Productions : RNDM Games.
- Matthew Sprange and Marc Miller. 2022. *Traveller Core Rulebook Update 2022*. 2nd ed. Traveller. Mongoose.
- Nepitello, Francesco. 2022. *The One Ring. Roleplaying in the World of The Lord of the Rings*. Stockholm: Free League.

Novoa, Andree. 2024. *The Job*. Games Ombivorous.

https://gamesomnivorous.com/pages/the-job?srsId=AfmBOoqx-UCa791FpmOvbd4z_9GJBVPzojbQueartM93pwHTDxsDU6L2.

Olavsrud, Thor, and Luke Crane. 2021. *Torchbearer: Dungeoneer's Handbook & the Scholar's Guide*.

Second Edition. New York, NY: Burning Wheel.

Peter Hollinghurst. 2015. *Fortunes Wheel*. www.fortuneswheel.co.uk.

Ravachol, Epidiah, and Nat Barmore. 2006. *Dread*. The Impossible Dream.

Robbins, Ben. 2011. *Microscope: A Fractal Role-Playing Game of Epic Histories*. First edition. [U.S.]:
Lame Mage Publications.

———. 2013. *Kingdom: A Role-Playing Game about Communities*. 1st ed. U.S.: Lame Mage
Publications.

Ryuutama: Natural Fantasy RPG. 2017. Place of publication not identified: publisher not identified.

Spenser Starke, Rowan Hall, and Matthew Mercer. 2025. *Daggerheart Core Set*. Darrington Press.

Stafford, Greg. 2024. *Pendragon: Core Rulebook*. Chaosium.

Stålenhag, Simon, Matt Forbeck, Nils Karlén, and Björn Hellqvist. 2021. *Tales from the Loop:
Roleplaying in the '80s That Never Was*. Edited by Tomas Härenstam.

Stewart, Sam, and Jay Little. 2021. *Genesys: Core Rulebook*. Fantasy Flight Games.

Tomkin, Shawn. 2018. *Ironsworn*. Tomkin Press.

Tweet, Jonathan. 1995. *Everway*. Wizard of the Coast.

Walsh, April Kit. 2021. *Thirsty Sword Lesbians*. Silver Spring, MD: Evil Hat Productions.

Wick, John. 2016. *7th Sea: Core Rulebook*. 2nd ed. John Wick Presents.

Web Resources

'BoardGameGeek'. 2026. Wiki. Accessed January 30. <https://boardgamegeek.com/>.

Dave Thaumavore. 2026. 'Dave Thaumavore RPG Reviews'. *YouTube*. Accessed March 3.
https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCbIl96w4kNeK_5HZrQWS9oA.

'Game Design Thinking'. 2026. *YouTube*. Accessed January 30.
<https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCGmxNOQoWHzUzYrEeLRpxzQ>.

Melinda. 2026. 'Knights of Last Call'. *YouTube*. Accessed February 7.
<https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCIVOFu4geOx5KrTTOwtlyMg>.

Quintin Smith. 2026. 'Quinns Quest'. *YouTube*. Accessed March 3.
https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCCJD5wGU6pLiCHKH2Sr_4fg.

'RPGGeek'. 2026. Wiki. Accessed January 30. <https://rpggeek.com/>.

Seth Skorkowsky. 2026. 'Seth Skorkowsky'. *YouTube*. Accessed March 3.
<https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCQs8-UJ7IHsrzhQ-OQOYBmg>.

Knights of Last Calls

- Derik Melenda, dir. 2022a. *Building Encounter Frameworks- Knight School Ep.004 - Design Your First Dungeon!* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uBfqll7leis>.
- , dir. 2022b. *Run D&D and PF Better - The 12 Principles of Dungeon World.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=J5oDS1dFyDI>.
- , dir. 2022c. *Better Combat Encounters - Knight School Ep.006 - Designing Your First Dungeon!* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pS8n-ljrQ74>.
- , dir. 2022d. *Pathfinder Encounter and Creature Construction - Knight School Live! - Livestream #36.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e14jgceWxsI>.
- , dir. 2023a. *Megadungeon Layout and Design - Dungeon23 - Knight School Live! - Livestream #54.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WFPBfjCiIlg>.
- , dir. 2023b. *Oracles: Get the Most out of the Mythic Gamemaster Emulator and Random Tables! - Livestream #58.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=U2oasAhrqh0>.
- , dir. 2023c. *Should TTRPGs Have Personality Mechanics? - Table Talk - Livestream #72.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LAp0KRGEvmk>.
- , dir. 2023d. *Player Agency - the MOST ESSENTIAL ELEMENT of TTRPGS! - Livestream #84.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=E9TJQZ6nGbY>.
- , dir. 2023e. *GMing in the Dark -Advice for Running Blades in the Dark and Other FITD Games! - Livestream #91.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FjsqxOr2ZsY>.
- , dir. 2023f. *Building and Running Your Own Sandbox Campaign - Knight School - Livestream #95.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RJ-4dGdo-IM>.
- , dir. 2023g. *All The Damn Time - Time Management in TTRPGS - Livestream #132.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=L7Ee9mXDigg>.
- , dir. 2023h. *Death and Dying in TTRPGs - Livestream #144.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-ePzZK-OGKE>.
- , dir. 2023i. *Death and Dying in TTRPGs - Livestream #144.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-ePzZK-OGKE>.
- , dir. 2023j. *Designing Encounters in 4e D&D... It's Actually Fun! - Livestream #154.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=feKdG6ffWkl>.
- , dir. 2024a. *Mastering the Art of PbtA and Forged in the Dark - Strategies for Common Problems - Livestream #166.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=t5gJJwL-78c>.
- , dir. 2024b. *More Tips and Tricks for PbtA and FitD - Dungeon World Blades in the Dark & More! - Livestream #167.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EcdRpbNCvkg>.
- , dir. 2024c. *XP or Milestone? Level-Based or Skill-Based? -- Talking RPG Progression Systems -- Livestream #196.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WFrnhYW6AQc>.
- , dir. 2024d. *Dynamic Random Encounters -- Livestream #197.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8cHf9csAVc>.
- , dir. 2024e. *GM Skills: Communication (Part 1 of 6) -- Livestream #203.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-GFPtO3wP2U>.

- , dir. 2024f. *GM Skills: Part 2 -- Prep. -- Livestream #205.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TRgtHkHhPqI>.
- , dir. 2024g. *GM Skills: Part 3 -- Improvisation -- Livestream #208.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pa4tWXCl1w>.
- , dir. 2024h. *GM Skills: Part 4 -- Adjudication and Mediation -- Livestream #208.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=chBM8CDggnw>.
- , dir. 2024i. *GM Skills: Part 5 -- Directing and Storytelling -- Livestream #213.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BBuJdRkqfGY>.
- , dir. 2024j. *How the Hell Are You Supposed to Run Powered by the Apocalypse Games? -- Livestream #226.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oYP5gGiOROk>.
- , dir. 2024k. *Unlocking the Secrets of TTRPG Metacurrencies - Livestream #244.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LY726UmlnAw>.
- , dir. 2025a. *Master of Time: Managing the Passage of Time in Your TTRPG Campaign -- Livestream #201 - YouTube.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vmPprroQ7r4>.
- , dir. 2025b. *Tome of World Building and The Nomicon - MOAR RANDOM TABLEZZZ - RPG First Look - Livestream #289.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4Pj5kkmc8QE>.
- , dir. 2025c. *DRAMA BY DESIGN: The Do's and Don'ts of Narrativist TTRPGs - Livestream #329.* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QNnTI9_Atuc.
- , dir. 2025d. *GMing Daggerheart: Prep Less, Play More- Livestream #330.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8lvuyuBE5n8>.
- , dir. 2025e. *Factions and Lore - Project: Shadowdeep - Part 7 - Livestream #361.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yaMLAB16kt4>.
- , dir. 2025f. *The Power of Friendship - Bonds and Friendship Mechanics in TTRPGs - Livestream #393.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0ZgYYuB78QE>.
- , dir. 2026. *Travel Systems in TTRPGs: From D&D to The One Ring, What Works and Why - Livestream #414.* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=10_IvYIpcoc.
- , dir. 2025a. *Master of Time: Managing the Passage of Time in Your TTRPG Campaign -- Livestream #201 - YouTube.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vmPprroQ7r4>.
- , dir. 2025b. *The Power of Friendship - Bonds and Friendship Mechanics in TTRPGs - Livestream #393.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0ZgYYuB78QE>.
- , dir. 2026. *Travel Systems in TTRPGs: From D&D to The One Ring, What Works and Why - Livestream #414.* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=10_IvYIpcoc.
- Knights of Last Call, dir. 2024a. *GM Skills: Part 2 -- Prep. -- Livestream #205.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TRgtHkHhPqI>.
- , dir. 2024b. *GM Skills: Part 3 -- Improvisation -- Livestream #208.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pa4tWXCl1w>.
- , dir. 2024c. *GM Skills: Part 4 -- Adjudication and Mediation -- Livestream #208.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=chBM8CDggnw>.
- , dir. 2024d. *GM Skills: Part 5 -- Directing and Storytelling -- Livestream #213.*
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BBuJdRkqfGY>.
- , dir. 2024e. *How the Hell Are You Supposed to Run Powered by the Apocalypse Games? -- Livestream #226.* <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oYP5gGiOROk>.

- , dir. 2024f. *Unlocking the Secrets of TTRPG Metacurrencies* - Livestream #244.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LY726UmlnAw>.
- , dir. 2025a. *Tome of World Building and The Nomicon* - MOAR RANDOM TABLEZZZ - RPG
First Look - Livestream #289. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4Pj5kkmc8QE>.
- , dir. 2025b. *DRAMA BY DESIGN: The Do's and Don'ts of Narrativist TTRPGs* - Livestream
#329. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QNnTI9_Atuc.
- , dir. 2025c. *GMing Daggerheart: Prep Less, Play More*- Livestream #330.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8lvuyuBE5n8>.
- , dir. 2025d. *Factions and Lore* - Project: Shadowdeep - Part 7 - Livestream #361.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yaMLABl6kt4>.